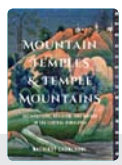
AT CLOSE RANGE

A reader's guide to the 'roof of the world'



HIMALAYA: A Human History
by Ed Douglas
BODLEY HEAD
₹799; 592 pages

There is very little that Ed Douglas leaves out in this comprehensive history of the Himalaya, but by repeatedly zooming in on the Himalayan people, he narrates a story of resilience we only seldom hear.



MOUNTAIN TEMPLES & TEMPLE MOUNTAINS: Architecture, Religion, and Nature in the Central Himalayas
by Nachiket Chanchani
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹1,600; 284 pages

Given the Ganga's unabating relevance in the Hindu pantheon, the river's Himalayan source is understandably venerated. Chanchani's book shows us how faith can even move mountains.



INTO THE HEART OF THE HIMALAYAS
by Jono Lineen
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 336 pages

To cope with the tragic loss of his brother, Jono Lineen trekked across 2,700 km of the Himalaya. His encounters with Pakistani army men, Tibetan lamas and Hindu sadhus all make this memoir absorbing.

BOOKS

COMING TO THE STOP

Vinoo N. Mathur's ode to Indian railway buildings makes you want to ditch the flight for the train

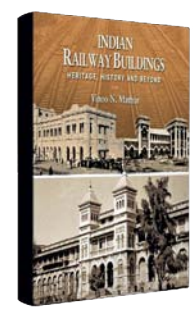
The British in India invested ideologically in the railways, and some of the most grand and monumental structures were colonial railway stations. Anyone interested in buildings cannot but fall in love with this legacy, and Vinoo Mathur, an old railway hand, has done a wonderful job of documentation. The book is a feast of rare archival and other photographs, the text has been meticulously researched and the author's grasp of the formal aspects of western architectural history is truly impressive. And it spans a range that includes chronological development, geographical spread, changing architectural styles, different functional needs—stations, offices, residential quarters, sheds and workshops, schools, hospitals, hotels.

The British themselves saw railway stations as islands of rational rule in the sea of traditional and backward India, examples of structured and regulated public spaces. No doubt these examples of Romanesque, Gothic, Saracenic buildings, complete with domes, arches, turrets and gargoyles, added a touch of the surreal and bizarre to the tropical landscape, but there were a few Indians, poor or rich, rural or urban, who remained unaffected or failed to be charmed. As standalone buildings, the careful planning, formal innovations—Roman temples, Gothic churches, Tudor cottages—appeared repeatedly, and their superb execution (by Indian workers, craftsmen and artisans) is endearing.

Railways and building activity gathered momentum after North India was reconquered in 1857. The concerns of defence lingered in the planning. Lahore station had bastions—just in case. Delhi, Agra and Lucknow had stations and railway lines cutting across them—these cities would no longer be fortified. Sanitation and land acquisition played a crucial role. Calcutta almost had Barrabazar wiped out so that a station could be built, which eventually happened across the river in Howrah. Railway buildings generated symbolic power and impressed stability and peace. Classical Europe was the model, but the buildings also benefited from innovations in techniques that came with the Industrial Revolution—the vast hangar-like sheds, the span of roofs, iron footbridges, the enormous platforms.

A book so lovingly written is bound to colour the view of British rule as admirable and benign. The author does not hint much at the darker legacy of railways: the spread of malaria, deindustrialisation and economic disruption where new termini replaced thriving marts to facilitate colonial extraction. But his enthusiasm for these architectural marvels will provoke thinking on the challenges of conserving historical buildings that have become integral to Indian culture, especially since there seems to be a trend to obliterate material remains that do not conveniently fit the narrative of contemporary political dispensations. Modern airports with their branded goods outlets and moving walkways can never replace the wonder and joy of the station experience. ■

Partho Datta



INDIAN RAILWAY BUILDINGS: HERITAGE, HISTORY AND BEYOND
by Vinoo N. Mathur
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹2,500; 365 pages